
New learning, old theology: Renaissance biblical humanism, scripture, and the question of theological method

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*New learning, old theology: Renaissance
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of theological method*

N. SCOTT AMOS

It commonly has been observed that one of the most characteristic academic activities of the first generation of Protestant Reformers was to lecture on the Bible. The explosion of commentaries written on virtually every one of its books in the first half of the sixteenth century is evidence enough to substantiate this observation, and many, if not most, of these commentaries had their origins in lectures. It has also been observed that this same era did *not* produce much in the way of 'systematic' theology – Philip Melanchthon's *Loci communes* and John Calvin's *Institutes* are the exceptions that prove the rule.¹ What is often overlooked, however, is the connection between these two observations, a connection that is more than coincidental. Not only were lectures on the Bible a characteristic activity of most of the early Reformers, but such lectures were also the occasion upon which many of them chose to 'do' theology. Exegesis did not just contribute materials for the construction of theology – exegesis *itself* was regarded by them as the central theological task. It would be easy to characterize this strictly as a phenomenon of the presumed 'biblicism' of the first generation of Protestant Reformers, and to view their concurrent dismissal of scholasticism (the theological method to which they were opposed) solely in the light of the confessional and polemical debates of their time. However, to do so would be to lose sight of the fact that their 'new' method was first advocated not by the Reformers in the first instance, but rather by the biblical humanists of the fifteenth and early sixteenth centuries – and thus to miss a lesser-known connection that may well have obtained between the Renaissance and the Reformation. The importance for the Reformation of the 'new learning' of Renaissance humanism (in the guise of the exegetical methods of biblical humanism) is a familiar subject, even if of late it has received less attention than it merits. Yet biblical humanism was important not only for the methodological tools of grammatical-historical exegesis, but also for the articulation of an

¹ And, it should be noted, the former work was originally written as a guide to reading scripture; the latter began as a catechism which then itself grew into a similar handbook for reading scripture.

approach to the practice of theology that was rooted in exegesis and which made the exegesis of scripture *the* central theological task in a manner that it had not been for some time. The purpose of the present essay is principally to explore this aspect of Renaissance biblical humanism (and only secondarily to note the suggestive implications it had for theological method as it was practised in the early Reformation). It will be argued that this aspect of biblical humanism, itself an application of humanist method more broadly understood, marked a significant discontinuity with respect to the late medieval period both for the Renaissance and – to the extent that this method was employed by the early Reformers – for the Reformation, and thus deserves more attention than has been given to it heretofore.² These two aspects of biblical humanism, in the context of the age in which they arose and developed, became all but indissolubly tied together and posed a radical challenge to the prevailing (scholastic) model of theological method, a challenge that would have profound implications for the early Reformation.

The context to which I have referred is that of the humanist/scholastic debate, which took place over the course of the fifteenth and early sixteenth centuries. This conflict was a significant facet of the broader development of humanism in northern Europe in this same period, of which biblical humanism was an important part. Recent research on the debate has focused attention upon the fact that this debate was at heart over the question of intellectual method:³ it was (simply put) an academic turf war, and as such took place primarily in the universities of northern Europe.⁴ Perhaps the most acrimonious aspect of this dispute was the argument over who was competent to interpret scripture,⁵ which in turn led to the broader question of what constituted the proper theological method. It is this latter question that is of particular interest to the present essay, as it has received less attention

² The question of the intellectual roots of the Protestant Reformation continues to be much debated, and the nature of the Reformation's relationship to the late medieval period that preceded it forms the focus of much recent work. Whereas it was once a settled conclusion that discontinuity was the strongest feature of this relationship, the continuities between the periods have come to be stressed with increasing frequency. In this, the importance of late medieval theology has come to be highlighted, and we have learned better to understand the Reformation within the medieval context out of which it grew. However, the discontinuous aspect of this tumultuous period cannot be overlooked, and in that respect the contribution of the Renaissance humanists, especially the biblical humanists, figures prominently.

³ See especially: Erika Rummel, *The Humanist-Scholastic Debate in the Renaissance and Reformation* (Cambridge, MA, 1994); Charles G. Nauert, Jr, *Humanism and the Culture of Renaissance Europe* (Cambridge, 1995); and *idem*, 'Humanism as method: roots of the conflict with the scholastics,' *Sixteenth Century Journal*, 29/2 (1998), 427–38.

⁴ Although this aspect of the debate was largely a phenomenon of the universities of northern Europe, its origins can be traced to the middle of the fourteenth century (most notably in the work of the great humanist Petrarch), when the regnant intellectual method we know as scholasticism began to be subjected to searching criticism by the humanists, dedicated as they were to the *studia humanitatis*. Humanism *vis-à-vis* theology did not become a point of bitter contention until it moved north of the Alps, where it encountered a formidable and well-entrenched scholastic establishment. Scholasticism was never prominent in Italy, nor (for that matter) was the teaching of theology.

⁵ On this, see Rummel, *Humanist-Scholastic Debate*, 83–95.

in historical scholarship to date.⁶ Thus, the focus below will be upon the humanist critique of scholastic method – including dialectic – and how that method was applied in the study of theology – specifically in the handling of authoritative texts, most importantly the Bible.⁷

Before turning to the humanist critique of scholasticism, some discussion of scholastic theological method is necessary – though admittedly what follows is to some extent presented from the perspective of its humanist critics in that I concentrate on those elements that feature in their critique.⁸ In the early medieval period, theology continued to be centred on the study of the Bible – following the pattern of the Patristic era – and one does not find much in the way of a systematic or speculative theology.⁹ However, beginning in the twelfth century and concurrent with the rise of the schools of northern France, a bifurcation began to develop in sacred studies between the study of the Bible and a more systematic and speculative study that became theology proper.¹⁰ At the outset of this development, theology continued to be closely tied to the exegesis of scripture to the extent that its purpose was initially to resolve problems that arose in the course of biblical interpretation.¹¹ The scholastic method from its origins was just that – a *method* of examining problems posed by the entire spectrum of academic study.¹² In the practice of theology, the scholastic master gave lectures on an authoritative text (chiefly the Bible), in the course of which he would address all issues posed by the text and provide a solution to all problems.¹³ Dialectic in particular became the distinctive and dominant intellectual tool, coming to claim for itself the mantle of the universal method. In this connection, one can regard the opening sentence of one of the standard texts on dialectic,

⁶ Although see the works of Nauert and those of Rummel, noted above. For what follows, I am indebted to their work.

⁷ Some consideration will also be given to the related questions of the goal of theology, and the place of philosophy in theology.

⁸ In what follows, I am dependent upon a number of very useful works. First, there are the three studies of G. R. Evans: *The Language and Logic of the Bible: The Earlier Middle Ages* (Cambridge, 1984); *The Language and Logic of the Bible: The Road to Reformation* (Cambridge, 1985); and *Old Arts and New Theology* (Oxford, 1980). Also important is James Overfield, *Humanism and Scholasticism in Late Medieval Germany* (Princeton, 1984). It needs to be stressed that the biblical humanists were reacting principally to late medieval developments. To what extent they were aware of scholastic method 'at its best' is an open question.

⁹ Evans, *Old Arts*, 39.

¹⁰ *Ibid.* 30. She notes that the two were 'distinct and not easily reconciled', and significantly, that in the new discipline of theology 'Scriptural passages serve principally to pose problems or to furnish proofs for use in problem solving'. It should be noted that the earlier pattern of theology continued to be practised: see Jean Leclercq, *The Love of Learning and the Desire for God: A Study of Monastic Culture* (New York, 1961).

¹¹ Evans, *Old Arts*, 92.

¹² Reference in current literature on scholasticism as a method is often made to the definition offered by J. A. Weisheipl in his article, 'Scholastic method' in *New Catholic Encyclopedia* (New York, 1967), xii, 1145–6. So too we should note that humanism is primarily an intellectual method. See especially Paul O. Kristeller, *Renaissance Thought: The Classic, Scholastic and Humanist Strains* (New York, 1961).

¹³ 'To understand a particular problem, words, ideas, and realities had to be clearly defined, distinguished, and examined from all sides. Recognition of a problem meant appreciation of all arguments *sic et non* . . . a specific question. Such questions could arise from the text, conflicting interpretations, doubtful solutions, or new insights; these gave rise to the disputation' (Weisheipl, 'Scholastic method', 1145).

Summulae logicales of Peter of Spain (d. 1277), as a representative statement: 'Dialectica est ars artium scientia scientiarum ad omnium methodorum principia viam habens.'¹⁴ The recovery of the full corpus of Aristotle's writings in the twelfth and thirteenth centuries only added momentum to a movement already under way, and secured for dialectic the total dominance of the university curriculum and thus of theology.¹⁵

What place in theology did scripture hold in light of these developments? As noted above, the Bible was at the foundation of theology as it came to be practised, but with advances in dialectical method the central place occupied in the practice of theology by exegesis of the Bible came to be displaced by more systematic, speculative concerns. While at the outset the questions central to theology were dealt with as they arose from the interpretation of the biblical text, the drive to devise a systematic structure for the discipline led to the employment of alternative and more 'orderly' means – initially the order of the Apostle's Creed, which in turn led to the development of the later and much more elaborate *summae*.¹⁶ With this latter development, the place of the Bible in theology was subtly altered. In practice, it was no longer the principal object of study in itself, but rather the source of texts for either disputation or as proof for an argument.¹⁷ Thus, as theology developed as a discipline, it focused increasingly on questions initially prompted by scripture but which were gradually separated from the text of scripture, and the organization of these questions provided the organization of theology. The result was that 'the systematic consideration of questions in order pushed Scriptural elements back',¹⁸ even to the point of secondary importance.

What of the humanist critique of scholasticism? It should be noted that in its initial stages, the humanist movement was *not* antagonistic towards the scholastic establishment, and in fact in Italy the two lived in relative peace throughout the period under consideration – though this was so to a significant extent because humanism in Italy was concerned principally with secular literature. Even so, from the beginning one can see among the Italians roots of the later conflict, particularly in the thought of Petrarch. There were a number of key elements to the humanist critique: antipathy towards metaphysics, which had a bearing on the purpose of theology; the hubris of the dialecticians arising from their claims to possess *the* universal method; the manner in which texts were handled by the scholastics. In each case, the fundamental issue ultimately was how one studied and applied the Bible in theology. To begin with, humanists were critical of metaphysics in

¹⁴ This quotation is taken from a copy held in the Rare Books Collection of Cambridge University Library: *Textus et copulata omnium Tractatum Petri Hispani. etiam Parvum Logicalium* (Nuremberg, 1494), Biii^r. See Overfield's discussion in *Humanism and Scholasticism*, 30.

¹⁵ Overfield, *Humanism and Scholasticism*, 27–43.

¹⁶ Weisheipl, 'Scholastic method', 1145.

¹⁷ Evans, *Road to Reformation*, 108–14 *passim*.

¹⁸ *Ibid.* 110.

theology. Briefly, for them theology should be concerned with living the Christian life, not with abstract speculation. It should be concerned with the Bible, not with philosophy. Far too often, in their view, metaphysics resulted in vain (even impious) speculation and linguistic quibbles about the arcane meaning of words, or 'ceaseless controversy over issues that were at once insoluble and probably unimportant'.¹⁹ While admittedly not many humanists were capable of mounting a thorough critique of scholastic metaphysics, 'they generally subscribed to the intentions of such criticisms'.²⁰

Where the humanist criticism of scholastic method became more pointed was in respect of the claim to universality, a claim that in their view bordered on hubris. Indeed, if the humanist critics are to be believed, the hubris of some dialecticians was such that they scorned even the Church Fathers, who were pitied because they were ignorant of this universal method. More than anything else, though, what aroused the ire of humanists was the manner in which texts were handled by the scholastics. This was true whether the subject of lectures was a biblical book or a secular book. In formal study, according to the canons of dialectic (as the humanists understood them), individual texts were treated as expressions of a given timeless truth, all too often with little sensitivity to what the original author might have meant. It is no exaggeration to state that in scholastic theology in particular, authoritative writings were not taken whole, but rather in piecemeal fashion – and this included the Bible.²¹ Statements were extracted from them (*sententiae*), and these in turn were gathered into anthologies organized according to issues (*quaestiones*), further removing them from their original context. Peter Lombard's *Book of Sentences* provides the best example of this procedure. The virtue of the method was that it 'probed each issue in an orderly and rational way'.²² But when it came to reading the material so collected, 'logic and metaphysics, not philology, provided [the Scholastics] with the means of understanding a text'.²³ In the view of the humanists, the result was that violence was done to the texts. It was a distortion of the original to extract statements from a larger body of work and then treat such statements as the adequate expression of a writer's thought.²⁴ In effect, the humanists charged, the authors of these texts disappeared; their statements were removed from the original context, treated as abstract expressions and applied to questions they did not necessarily raise themselves. The original statements were thus

¹⁹ Overfield, *Humanism and Scholasticism*, 94.

²⁰ John F. D'Amico, 'Humanism and pre-Reformation theology', in Albert Rabil, Jr (ed.), *Renaissance Humanism: Foundations, Forms, and Legacy* (3 vols; Philadelphia, 1988), III, 351.

²¹ It has been remarked of the method of Thomas Aquinas that 'in this enterprise the Bible was (put invidiously) a book of sacred information that provided the data for an intellectual construct' (John W. O'Malley, 'Introduction', *Collected Works of Erasmus* [Toronto, 1988], vol. 66, xxvi).

²² Nauert, *Humanism*, 18.

²³ John F. D'Amico, *Theory and Practice in Renaissance Textual Criticism: Beatus Rhenanus between Conjecture and History* (Berkeley, 1988), 27.

²⁴ Nauert, 'Humanism as method,' 434.

opened to subtle and (perhaps) not so subtle reshaping at the hands of theologians.²⁵

However, as noted above, for the most part Italian humanists took a benign view of scholasticism, if we leave aside their criticisms of what they believed were its sophistries and mishandling of texts. Conflict – in Italy, at least – was more episodic than sustained. Yet even in Italy scholastic method was not without its vociferous critics, and of the Italian humanists, none was more scathing in his critique of it than Lorenzo Valla (1407–57) – best known for his exposure of the Donation of Constantine as a forgery and only slightly less well known for his writings on language and on logic, but who should be better known for his contribution to theology, though not himself a theologian.²⁶ In opposition to the scholastic theologians, Valla argued vigorously that theology should be based exclusively upon the text of scripture and upon those Fathers who themselves built their theology on the basis of exegesis, avoiding the use of philosophy as far as was possible.²⁷

Valla's critique of scholastic method was most extensively stated in *Repastinatio Dialectice et Philosophiae*,²⁸ it was most concisely and provocatively stated in a lesser-known work, his *Encomium sancti Thomae Aquinatis*,²⁹ delivered on 7 March 1457, shortly before his death, to a gathering of the Dominican Order in Rome – a daring bit of bravado when one considers that the great doctor emerges from Valla's oration as distinctly inferior to the Church Fathers.³⁰ In this work Valla explicitly expressed two of the three features of the humanist critique we noted above: a rejection of metaphysics, and a defence of the Fathers against the disparagements of the scholastics.³¹ After praising Aquinas in relatively conventional terms for the first half of the oration, Valla turns his attention to the reasons his contemporaries give for exalting the great doctor above all others:

²⁵ Nauert, *Humanism*, 18. As Nauert goes on to say, 'To read merely in order to pluck out information and general opinions was to miss the point – indeed, to distort the point' (19).

²⁶ See M. Fois, *Il pensiero cristiano di Lorenzo Valla nel quadro storico-culturale del suo ambiente* (Rome, 1969) and Salvatore Camporeale, *Lorenzo Valla: umanesimo e teologia* (Florence, 1972). Literature in English on this aspect of Valla's thought is sparse, but see M. L. McLaughlin, *Literary Imitation in the Italian Renaissance. The Theory and Practice of Literary Imitation from Dante to Bembo* (Oxford, 1995), 138–9.

²⁷ Recently, James Tracy has drawn attention to this facet of Valla's thought in *Erasmus of the Low Countries* (Berkeley, 1996), 58–62.

²⁸ Available in a recent edition: Gianni Zippel, *Laurentii Vallae Repastinatio Dialectice et Philosophie* (2 vols, Padua, 1982).

²⁹ The text quoted below is *Laurentii Vallae encomium sancti Thomae Aquinatis*, ed. J. Vahlen and printed in Laurentius Valla, *Opera Omnia, tomus alter*, ed. Eugenio Garin. Monumenta Politica et Philosophica Rariora, Series I, Numerus 6 (Torino, 1962), 340–52 (text, 346–52). An English translation can be found in L. A. Kennedy (ed.), *Renaissance Philosophy: New Translations* (The Hague, 1973), 13–27. Page references in parentheses are to the English translation.

³⁰ Salvatore Camporeale, *Valla*, 3. Notice should be taken of his treatment of this piece in Camporeale, 'L. Valla, tra medioevo e rinascimento. *Encomium Sanctae Thomae* – 1457,' *Memoriae domenicane*, n.s. 7 (1976), 3–190.

³¹ However, as we shall see, the place of the Bible lay behind much of what he wrote.

Cur autem eundem possint omnibus praeponere, hinc demonstrabant, quod dicerent, eum ad probationem theologiae adhibere logicam, metaphysicam atque omnem philosophiam, quam superiores doctores vix primis labiis degustassent. Lubricus hic mihi et anceps locus non modo propter sancti, cuius de laudibus loquimur, dignitatem, sed etiam propter molitam apud plerosque opinionem, neminem posse sine dialecticorum, metaphysicorum, ceterorum philosophorum praeceptis evadere theologum.³²

Although he has emphasized his regard for Aquinas as a doctor of the Church, it becomes clear that this regard has little to do with his method in theology. Valla's disregard for metaphysics emerges at this point, and he begins his argument against its employment in theology – indeed, his argument is against the use of Greek philosophy generally in sacred studies:

Ista autem, quae vocant metaphysica et modos significandi et alia id genus, quae recentes theologi tamquam novam sphaeram nuper inventam aut planetarum epicyclos admirantur, nequaquam ego tantopere admiror, nec ita multum interesse arbitror scias an nescias, et quae forte sit satius nescire tamquam meliorum impedimenta.³³

The reliance of scholastic method on metaphysics makes it not superior to the Fathers, but decidedly inferior.

What is interesting is that Valla proceeds not by ridiculing scholastic terminology, but by arguing that the Fathers, who were masters of Latin and who knew Greek – and by implication, knew classical culture and thought – did not themselves employ either metaphysics or such terms as were in vogue among the new theologians – even though the Fathers stood in closer proximity to the sources of classical philosophy than did the scholastics:

neque id meis argumentis planum faciam, etsi possem facere, sed veterum theologorum auctoritate, qui tantum abest ut hoc in libris suis tractaverint, ut ne nomina quidem ipsa scripta reliquerint, Cyprianus, Lactantius, Hilarius, Ambrosius, Hieronymus, Augustinus. An scilicet ob ignorationem? Qui fieri potest? Nam sive in nostra lingua fundamentum haec habent, illi latinissimi fuerunt, recentes autem omnes paene barbari; sive in graeca, illi graeca noverunt, isti ignorant. Cur igitur non tractaverint? Quia tractanda non fuerunt, et forte etiam ignoranda, idque duabus de causis, una rerum, altera verborum.³⁴

³² Valla, *Encomium*, 349 (22).

³³ *Ibid.* 350 (23).

³⁴ *Ibid.* 350 (23).

Valla argues that it is simply inappropriate to employ Greek philosophy in the task of theology. It can supply neither the substance of theology, nor its terminology.

Regarding facts or substance, Valla argues that metaphysics does not lead to a knowledge of God, and claims he has the support of Basil, Gregory the Great, John Chrysostom, and others – men who ‘... neque dialecticorum ratiunculas neque metaphysicas ambages neque modorum significandi nugas in quaestionibus sacris admiscendas putaverunt, ac ne in philosophia quidem suarum disputationum fundamenta iecerunt, cum Paulum clamantem legerent “non per philosophiam et inanem fallaciam” [Coloss 2.8]’.³⁵ Regarding words or terminology, he argues:

hoc dixisse sit satis, hos doctores ecclesiae latinos reformidasse vocabula, quae auctores latinos, id est suos in loquendo magistros, graecarum litterarum eruditissimos numquam viderant usurpasse, quae novi theologi semper inculcant, ens, entitas, quiditas, identitas, reale, essenziale, suum esse, et verba illa, quae dicuntur, ampliari, dividi, componi, et alia huius modi. Ergo haec non minima ex parte nugatoria aut non tractanda fuerunt illis aut ignoranda, ne magna ignorarent.³⁶

Valla claims that his point in all this is not to attack the new theologians – though one suspects he doth protest too much – but rather to defend the old, and at this point he advances an important argument regarding the ultimate model of theology. In defence of the Fathers he argues that they have been

iniuste reprehensos sigillatosque . . . quod non sunt hunc in modum theologati, sed se totos ad imitandum Paulum apostolum contulerunt, omnium theologorum longe principem ac theologandi magistrum, cuius is est dicendi modus, ea vis, ea maiestas, ut quae sententiae apud alios etiam apostolos iacent, eae sint apud hunc erectae, quae apud alios stant, apud hunc proelientur, quae apud alios vix fulgent, apud hunc fulgurare et ardere videantur . . .³⁷

What is noteworthy in this address is that Valla stressed the centrality of the Bible as not only the source of theology, but also the model of theology (pointing to the Apostle Paul in particular as a theologian):

Hic est verus et ut dicitur germanus theologandi modus, haec vera dicendi et scribendi lex, quam qui sectantur, ii profecto optimum dicendi genus

³⁵ *Ibid.* 350 (23).

³⁶ *Ibid.* 350 (23–4).

³⁷ *Ibid.* 350 (24).

theologandique sectantur. Quare non est, ut illis veteribus, vere Pauli discipulis, hoc nomine, quod ab his philosophia theologiae [non] admisceantur, aut detrahant novi theologi aut noster Thomas sit praeponendus.³⁸

Valla concluded his *Encomium* with a refusal to place Aquinas before the four great doctors of the Church, though he was willing to make him the first among the moderns. At most, he was willing to permit him a place alongside the Four.³⁹

Valla's oration, though little known in his day, is expressive of a significant development in the growth of biblical humanism – the Bible is seen as the source of theology but, in addition, it is *itself* seen as an expression of theology (albeit of an entirely different order from that written by non-biblical authors), and one that should provide the pattern for contemporary theology. Hence, a further impetus is given to the movement towards the restoration of the exegesis of scripture as *the* primary theological task. If theology is to take its bearings from the model found in scripture, and in the Fathers who themselves followed scripture in this, then the restoration of theology to its true method must proceed first by a careful study and analysis of the text of scripture. In this connection, what is especially significant about Valla is that he is among the earliest to articulate an argument for an alternative model for theology.

This development is all the more important in the light of Valla's work on the text of the New Testament – all of which preceded this oration – where he sought to correct the text of the Vulgate by means of a comparison with the text of the Greek New Testament.⁴⁰ In respect of his contribution to the development of biblical humanism, it was this text-critical work that was his most tangible achievement. It has been suggested that Valla was among the first to recognize that a textual study of the Bible in the manner that classical texts had been studied could become a powerful force for the reform and revival of Christianity.⁴¹ He maintained that divine truth could be apprehended only through 'linguistic, semantic and historical analysis of biblical language', and he himself employed the tools developed for the study of

³⁸ *Ibid.* 350 (24).

³⁹ *Ibid.* 350–2 (24–6). Regarding the oration, 'a historian contemporary with Valla, who was also a humanist, though not very friendly towards him, relates that the speech was poorly received by several in the audience. . . . It must be noted that, in fact, the text of the oration is preserved only in a few manuscript copies and that it was only published comparatively recently' (Paul O. Kristeller, 'Thomism and Italian thought of the Renaissance', in *idem*, *Medieval Aspects of Renaissance Learning* [Durham, NC, 1974], 64).

⁴⁰ For this aspect of Valla's scholarly work, see Jerry H. Bentley, *Humanists and Holy Writ: New Testament Scholarship in the Renaissance* (Princeton, 1983). It is, I think, highly suggestive that Valla delivered his oration on Thomas – in which he expressed his views on theology and its relation to Scripture – *after* a long period of close philological and textual work on the Bible.

⁴¹ Charles Trinkaus, *In Our Image and Likeness: Humanity and Divinity in Italian Humanist Thought* (2 vols, Chicago, 1970), II, 577.

classical literature in the study of scripture and its interpretation.⁴² In his hands, these methods provided an enhanced understanding of both the historical context of the New Testament texts and hence of their meaning.⁴³

As important as Valla's achievement was, it was the work of Desiderius Erasmus (1467–1535) that was unquestionably the most important for the development in northern Europe of biblical humanism and the attempt at a redefinition of the task of theology. Whereas in Italy most of the humanists were concerned principally with secular literature, Erasmus was principally concerned with sacred literature. It was his lifework to provide for a restitution of Christendom through the application of the tools of humanism to the study of the Bible, which would in turn lead to a renewal of the 'true' or 'old' theology, and in so doing he became the leading proponent of what is now recognized as biblical humanism. It is no coincidence that his efforts in this regard proceeded along two tracks: most importantly, his work on the New Testament; but also of great significance, his work in producing editions of the Church Fathers, whom he held up as exemplars of the theological method that he sought to promote.

It was Erasmus, more than any other single individual, who mediated the achievements of the Italian Renaissance to northern Europe. This is particularly the case with regard to the interpretation of scripture and even the text of scripture itself.⁴⁴ Virtually every Reformer of note in the early Reformation applied exegetical methods that owed much to humanism in general, and to Erasmus in particular. *Methodologically* speaking, Erasmus was the mentor of a generation of exegetes, though in time he came to disown many who claimed his paternity and authority for their practice. But in conveying an exegetical method, he also conveyed a theological method. For Erasmus, the two were bound together; a proper exegetical method was at the same time a proper theological method, and the central object of both was scripture.

The primary vehicle by which he transmitted his method of exegesis, and what made the work of Erasmus so important for the developments regarding the close relationship of scripture and theology, was his landmark scholarly achievement – the *Novum Instrumentum*⁴⁵ of 1516, the critical text of the Greek New Testament with a fresh Latin translation and annotations on difficult passages in the Vulgate with references to the Greek originals. The text was not an end in itself, but was intended ultimately and fundamentally

⁴² Ronald G. Witt, 'The humanist movement,' in Thomas A. Brady, Jr, Heiko A. Oberman, and James D. Tracy (eds), *Handbook of European History 1400–1600* (2 vols; Leiden, 1995), II, 107.

⁴³ Bentley, *Humanists and Holy Writ*, 60.

⁴⁴ It should be noted that Erasmus drew a tremendous amount of material (as well as inspiration) from Valla for this aspect of his life's work. His discovery of a manuscript copy of Valla's *Adnotationes* on the New Testament in 1504 was of tremendous significance for him. Erika Rummel has noted: 'there can be no doubt . . . that Valla's work was an inspiration to Erasmus and confirmed the direction of his studies': see Rummel, *Erasmus' Annotations on the New Testament: from Philologist to Theologian* (Toronto, 1986), x.

⁴⁵ He changed the title to the more conventional *Novum testamentum* in the second and subsequent editions.

to promote a renewal of the 'old theology', best exemplified by Origen, Augustine, and Jerome.⁴⁶ Not only was the text itself a monumental accomplishment, but accompanying it was prefatory material that has a particular significance for the issues raised in this paper, especially the discussion of exegesis and its relation to theology found in the *Methodus*, which was later expanded in 1518/19 into the much longer and more detailed *Ratio Verae Theologiae*. It is in this treatise – especially in its expanded version – that we find the most influential statement of his prescriptions for exegetical practice, but also his argument for the centrality of exegesis as the principal theological task.⁴⁷ The *Novum Instrumentum* was eagerly sought after by scholars desiring to study the Bible, especially by those of a reformist cast of mind, and because of the demand for this work his programme of biblical humanism was disseminated to the widest possible audience in close proximity to the text he believed essential for the renewal of theology – the Bible.⁴⁸

In its details, the *Ratio* was critically important as a means of transmitting humanist grammatical-historical method and it is most often treated in the secondary literature as a handbook of biblical interpretation. A survey of the text confirms that this is a reasonable conclusion, for one can see that it is replete with advice on how to deal with the various problems that arise in the course of exegesis. To the extent that it performed this function, it was significant enough in the context, but to read it as an exegetical handbook and nothing more is to lose sight of the overall goal Erasmus has in view. In its broad sweep, it was equally important – and perhaps even more radical in its implications – in arguing for an entirely different shape and goal for theology, rooted in the exegesis of scripture.⁴⁹ What is most distinctive about it is his call for the practice of exegesis to be the normative form of theology.⁵⁰ The title, after all, was 'the method of true *theology*' not 'true *exegesis*'. Exegesis and theology were of a piece; they were not separate tasks. Early in the work Erasmus makes what is the programmatic statement of his treatise: 'At praecipuus theologorum scopus est sapienter enarrare divinas litteras, de fide, non de frivolis quaestionibus rationem reddere, de pietate graviter

⁴⁶ James McConica, *Erasmus* (Oxford, 1991), 38.

⁴⁷ Erasmus, *Ratio seu Methodus Compendio Perveniendi ad Veram Theologiam* included in *Desiderius Erasmus Roterdamus: Ausgewählte Werke*, hrsg. Hajo Holborn und Annemarie Holborn (München, 1933, reprinted 1964), 175–305. In the text below, I will refer to this as *Ratio Verae Theologiae* or, more simply, *Ratio*. To my knowledge there is at present no English translation of this work apart from that found in Donald Bernard M. Conroy, 'The ecumenical theology of Erasmus of Rotterdam: a study of the *Ratio Verae Theologiae*, translated into English and annotated, with a brief account of his ecumenical writings and activities within his lifetime,' (Ph.D. diss., University of Pittsburgh, 1974), 71–366. I have benefited from working with this translation.

⁴⁸ The best recent work on Erasmus' theological programme is Manfred Hoffman, *Rhetoric and Theology: The Hermeneutic of Erasmus* (Toronto, 1994). See also Marjorie Boyle, *Erasmus on Language and Method in Theology* (Toronto, 1977); McConica, *Erasmus*, and Rummel, *Erasmus' Annotations*.

⁴⁹ Neal Gilbert briefly comments on Erasmus' *Ratio* and its object of conveying a new method of theology, but he does not go much further than observing, 'this reform of theological method could not fail to have important repercussions' (*Renaissance Concepts of Method* [New York, 1960], 108).

⁵⁰ See Boyle, *Language and Method*, 63 for her comments on this.

atque efficaciter disserere, lacrimas excutere, ad caelestia inflammare animos.⁵¹ Theology achieves its task by exegesis of the Bible.

In addition to the programmatic aspect of the *Ratio Verae Theologiae* – the concrete proposals advanced for exegesis as the principal task of theology – there is also a polemical aspect by which Erasmus undergirds his call for a different theological method. In the context of his age, it comes as no surprise that he makes his case by way of a contrast with the method of the scholastics, and in respect of the critique he offers we encounter little that is new in the substance of his remarks that we do not find among the humanists of the previous century.⁵² He repeats many of the same kinds of criticisms, though he expresses himself with his accustomed biting wit. In what follows, the discussion will conform to the same categories identified above in the general discussion of the humanist critique of scholastic method, though in a slightly different order.

Like the humanists we have already discussed, Erasmus rejects the assertion that dialectic is a sufficient method.⁵³ He ridicules those who attribute so much to the discipline ‘ut actum existiment de fide Christiana, nisi dialectices praesidiis fulciatur, cu[m] interim grammaticam ac rhetoricam ceu prorsus supervacaneas aspernentur’.⁵⁴ He turns to the example of scripture for support in this (and in so doing implicitly suggests that Paul himself is a theologian), asking: ‘Ubi tandem in his litteris, quod Aristotelem quamlibet argutum aut eruditum, quod impium Averroem referat? Ubi primarum et secundarum intentionem, ubi formarum syllogisticarum, ubi formalitatum aut quidditatum aut etiam eccitatum ulla mentio?’⁵⁵ Although the humanists were well known for their contempt of the ‘barbarity’ of scholastic language – and Erasmus was among the most acerbic on this issue – here the point is that neither the terminology of Aristotelian philosophy nor its form of argument appear in Paul’s discourse and is therefore alien to ‘true’ theology. For that matter, neither appear in the Fathers and thus, in addition to the example of the biblical writers, he appeals as well to the Fathers, asking, with regard to both: ‘ideo parum argute disserunt, quod non in conclusiones et

⁵¹ Erasmus, *Ratio*, 193, lines 18–22.

⁵² It is true that Erasmus was always careful to qualify his criticism of scholastics and their method, though one suspects this was more to guard himself against persecution by the authorities than out of any genuine regard for the opposition. He wrote in the introduction to his New Testament: ‘Non quod horum studium damnum, qui in argutiis huiusmodi non sine laude execuerunt ingenii sui vires, nolim enim offendi quemquam, sed quod existimem et vere, ni fallor, existimo puram ac germanam illam Christi philosophiam non aliunde felicius hauriri quam ex evangelicis libris, quam ex apostolicis litteris . . .’ Even in making a concession to scholasticism, he drains his words of any substance (Erasmus, *Paraclesis ad lectorem pium* in Holborn [ed.], *Ausgewählte Werke*, 146, lines 3–8). There is an English translation, ‘The Paraclesis,’ in *Christian Humanism and the Reformation: Selected Writings of Erasmus, with the Life of Erasmus by Beatus Rhenanus*, rev. edn ed. John C. Olin (New York, 1975), 101–2.

⁵³ There are some striking similarities of argument in what Erasmus wrote and what we have seen in Valla above.

⁵⁴ Erasmus, *Ratio*, 185, lines 31–4.

⁵⁵ *Ibid.* 191, lines 2–6.

corollaria dissecant omnia?’ Because they do not follow the approved method, announcing in advance what they are going to say and because they do not cut into pieces ‘sermonem omnem verbatim paene concisum’, are the Apostles and the Fathers therefore deficient?⁵⁶

Erasmus can find little value in the methods of the scholastics, and indeed sees in them only harm. To begin with, dwelling too long on issues of philosophy and dialectic can have a corrupting effect, as with those who ‘palatum ac linguam multo absinthio habeant infectam, iis quicquid deinde biberint aut ederint absinthium sapiat’.⁵⁷ Although he does not categorically deny the value of philosophy in itself, he refuses to be swayed by those who insist that it is essential for theology:

Quod si quis clamabit absque exacta horum cognitione non esse theologum, equidem consolabor me ipsum tot insignium virorum exemplis, Chrysostomi, Cypriani, Hieronymi, Ambrosii, Augustini, Clementis, cum quibus rhetorculus esse malim quam cum quibusdam, qui sibi plus quam homines videntur, theologus. Denique consolabor me ipsum exemplo Petri ac Pauli, qui ista non solum non calluerunt, verum etiam damnant aliquoties, certe constat nusquam usos esse.⁵⁸

So, far from being a valid universal method, dialectic has, through its heavy employment of philosophy, reduced theology to debates drawn from the subtleties of Aristotle, making it more like philosophy than theology.⁵⁹ To the objection that without a thorough grounding in philosophy, theologians will be poorly prepared for the task of theology (that is, for scholastic debates), he responds:

Neque vero nos pugilem instituimus, sed theologum, et eum theologum, qui quod profitetur malit exprimere vita quam syllogismis. Nec est, quod tibi tantopere displiceas, si inter istos parum theologus habearis, cum inter eosdem ne Hieronymus quidem ipse sit habiturus, quod respondeat, ac fortasse nec ipse Paulus.⁶⁰

It is clear that Erasmus argues that his readers should study the ancients, not the current writers. They should pattern theology according to the model of the Fathers, not the scholastics. What is noteworthy is that not only is Erasmus urging upon his readers reliance upon scripture as the source of theology, appealing to the example of the Fathers, but he also appeals to biblical examples of the kind of method he seeks to promote. The method of theology he calls for is (in his view) fundamentally a biblical method by both warrant and example.

⁵⁶ *Ibid.* 191, lines 7–11.

⁵⁷ *Ibid.* 192, lines 8–10.

⁵⁸ *Ibid.* 193, lines 1–8. The reference is to Aristotle and modern scholastic theologians.

⁵⁹ *Ibid.* 297, line 15.

⁶⁰ *Ibid.* 297, lines 7–12.

True to humanist form, Erasmus also faults the scholastic method in theology for its second-hand reliance upon authorities – including the Bible – through digests of texts, such as the *Sentences* of Lombard, and works which in turn rely upon Lombard for their own substance, works which ‘iam sescenties aliunde alio confusis ac refusis’. One of the chief hazards in following such a method is that it is all too easy to twist the Scriptures ‘ad alienos sensus, aliquoties et ad contrarios’.⁶¹ And again, the alternative he promotes is recourse to the source itself – whether that text be Scripture, or the writings of the Fathers. We see here the manifestation of the Renaissance slogan *ad fontes*, a call for a direct engagement with the sources of theology. At every turn, Erasmus calls for a redirection of theology from systems and digests to text – ultimately and fundamentally *the* text. In keeping with the principal thrust of the *Ratio*, Erasmus emphasizes that fundamental to theology is the task of *thoroughly* studying *all* of Scripture and directly, not at one remove – however wearying it might appear. He acknowledges that this is a time-consuming task, but he asks:

Quod si quos deterret hic labor, illud, quaeso, secum cogitet, qui conveniat, ut theologus futurus sophisticas praeceptiunculas ediscat, ediscat qualescumque in Aristotelem commentarios aut etiam paraphrasim, ediscat Scoti conclusiones quas vocant et argumenta, et idem operae gravetur dare libris divinis, ex quorum fontibus universa scatet theologia, quae modo vere sit theologia.⁶²

Like his predecessors, Erasmus faults scholasticism for its method, that is, for its use of dialectic, and its reliance upon digests. But he extends their criticism of the kinds of questions asked, arguing forcefully against the speculative character of ‘modern’ theology.⁶³ In part, his criticism was directed at what he believed to be the frivolous and pointless character of many of the questions posed by scholastic theologians.⁶⁴ But at the same time, in his criticism of the speculative character of scholasticism we touch upon an important element of the rhetorical (or, perhaps better, evangelical) character of his theology – that is, what the goal of theology should be.⁶⁵ The purpose of true theology for Erasmus was to delve deeply into scripture in order to

⁶¹ *Ibid.* 284, lines 31, 33–34.

⁶² *Ibid.* 294, lines 15–21.

⁶³ It should be noted that he could be as critical of speculative flights of fancy in the Fathers as he could be of the abstract speculations of the scholastics. Erasmus believed that in both cases, there was exhibited a disregard for the literal sense of the text and equally for the practical application of it.

⁶⁴ Erasmus, *Ratio*, 297, line 24 to 298, line 5.

⁶⁵ Charles Nauert observes: ‘Scholasticism assumed that the goal of human life is to know, and it emphasized logic because that subject guided the intellect in its endeavor to gain true knowledge. But humanists from the time of Petrarch had regularly rejected this glorification of knowledge and reason. They had instead viewed human beings as moral and social creatures whose primary goal was to live rightly rather than merely to know the truth’ (‘The humanist challenge to medieval German culture’, *Daphnis: Zeitschrift für mittlere deutsche Literatur*, 15 [1986], 301). It is obvious that Erasmus is markedly influenced by this latter line of thinking.

proclaim its truth 'in such a way that will move God's people to change their lives and the world about them'.⁶⁶ Scholastic theology, in his view, failed utterly to do this. It divorced theology from piety in its single-minded pursuit of truth for its own sake; its goal was simply to know. It raised countless questions that contribute nothing to the Christian life, and are alien to the text of scripture.⁶⁷ To the extent that it employed scripture in its development of doctrine, it was often to 'force' a text to answer a question that was irrelevant to the original author's intent, and all too often irrelevant to Christian life and true doctrine. Indeed, the questions themselves arose from other sources, and Erasmus again urges recourse to Scripture alone as the source of theology and the source of the true approach to theological inquiry:

... non dictum esse: 'Scrutamini philosophiam Aristotelicam, an eius praesidio doceri possit resurrectio mortuorum', sed: Scrutamini scripturas [John 5.39]. Atque inibi Paulus ostendens, quousque sit adhibendum arcanae scripturae scrutinium et ad quem scopum dirigenda theologiae cognitio: Finis, inquit, praecepti est caritas de corde puro et conscientia bona et fide non ficta [I Tim 1.5]. Hactenus igitur philosophandum in sacris litteris, quatenus industria nostra conducit ad ea, quae Paulus commemoravit. Verum qui sibi scopum hunc non proposuerunt, sed hoc agunt, ut paradoxa quaequam ac nova proferant, quo sint admirationi populo, semper inanum rerum admiratori, pro theologis fiunt mataelogi.⁶⁸

Erasmus is willing for both approaches to theology to coexist, but if a choice had to be made, he would opt for a biblically based method such as that for which he has argued:

Praestat paulo minus esse sophistam quam minus sapere in euangelicis et apostolicis litteris. Satius est ignorare quaedam Aristotelis dogmata quam nescire Christi decreta. Denique malim cum Chrysostomo pius esse theologus quam cum Scoto esse invictus.⁶⁹

What made his overall argument so electric in its original context was the stark simplicity of his counter-proposal: theology is exegesis of the Bible. On a fundamental level, his opponents would have been hard-pressed to deny his assertion.⁷⁰ It is both a simple programme and a profound critique of the

⁶⁶ McConica, *Erasmus*, 78.

⁶⁷ Erasmus, *Ratio*, 297, lines 18–20.

⁶⁸ *Ibid.* 300, line 30 to 301, line 6.

⁶⁹ *Ibid.* 304, lines 11–15.

⁷⁰ Although Nauert points to Jacobus Latomus, one of Erasmus' opponents in the second decade of the sixteenth century, who 'flatly denied that under modern conditions study of the text of Scripture should be the first or principal focus of theological education' ('Humanism as method', 434).

elaborate structure and speculative – indeed, academically professional – character of systematic theology.

The contribution of the biblical humanists to developments in exegetical methodology in the fifteenth and early sixteenth centuries is well known, but what is less well known is that their methods became, prior to the Reformation, part of a broader programme for the renewal of theology and the reconfiguration of theological method. Although this programme was most comprehensively worked out by Erasmus, we have seen that the various elements of his own method had their origin in the work of Italian humanists. Beginning with Petrarch, there is a line of thought that raised serious questions about the shape of theology, a line that can be traced through Valla and then north, where it found its fullest and most influential expression in the work of Erasmus. What is significant in this programme is that the exegesis of scripture is again made central to the theological task, and the latter was intended to take its terms and questions – as well as its answers – from the former. In arguing that exegesis of scripture was central to the development of theology and indeed the primary theological task, the biblical humanists threatened to undermine the structure of academic theology as it was practised at the time.⁷¹ The biblical humanists not only had the effrontery to claim control of the interpretation of the text, but they then compounded their offence by condemning scholastic method in theology and propounding an alternative model of their own. What Charles Nauert has observed with regard to Erasmus holds true for biblical humanism as a whole:

[I]n general he conceded that his work as biblical and patristic editor constituted only the humblest, most elementary level of theological scholarship. That is, it dealt with the text. But as his scholastic critics quickly sensed, his modest claim to control the text amounted to claiming control of the whole field.⁷²

The implications of all this for the Reformation are, I think, obvious. However much Erasmus may have wished it were otherwise, it is hard to avoid the conclusion that he, and the tradition which he represented, furnished an important tool to the first generation of Protestant Reformers, a tool which had far-reaching consequences for the content of theology, and which resulted – for a time, at least – in a significant measure of discontinuity in the practice of theology.

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⁷¹ And, again, this was *prior* to the Reformation.

⁷² Nauert, 'Humanism as method', 434.